

Nation **BACKROOM FACE-OFF**

Goodwill HUNTING

The brains trust is at full throttle as Congress and the BJP try their best to outwit each other in the campaign

| By Priya Sahgal and Bhavna Vij-Aurora |

Jai Ho (victory) says the Congress. *Haar ho* (may you lose) retaliates the BJP.

These are not slumdogs searching for lost love or waiting for that pot of money at the end of a quiz show. It's power that drives them. With elections just a month away, both the Congress and the BJP have activated their fabled war rooms where strategies are planned, slogans are coined and numbers crunched.

Hand Picked

The Congress has pitched its control centre at 15, Gurdwara Rakabganj Road. Geographically too, it's a strategic location with the BSP and NCP headquarters in the neighbourhood. Leading the team is Rahul Gandhi's favourite General Secretary Digvijay Singh. Helping him is the party's ace spin master Jairam Ramesh, the resident expert. He operates from a room filled with state-of-the-art computers manned by smart young techies who look more outsourced than homegrown. There is also a large map of India depicting different constituencies whose main *raison d'être* is to chalk out the 'champagne trail'—the Sonia and Rahul Gandhi election tours—and a conference room with large television screens. For those who want to brainstorm in more natural surroundings, there are garden chairs on the lawn outside with a 24-hour pantry on call.

In keeping with young Rahul's distrust of the press, a guard is posted

outside to keep the extras off the manicured lawns. The core team assembles here every evening at 7. In addition to Digvijay and Ramesh, the group includes Salman Khurshid, a legacy of the 2004 war room, Anand Sharma, Ambika Soni, Sheila Dikshit and Vishvijit Prithvijit Singh. In addition, there is the main sponsor Motilal Vohra, the treasurer who is needed to okay the spend; Veerappa Moily, the media in-charge whose role is self-explanatory; and to give the group gravitas, there is Ahmed Patel, the all-powerful political secretary to the Congress president. Ramesh in-



IMAGE FORUM

